

Apolitical referee or geopolitical actor? How artificial intelligence's national-origin labels shape credibility in politicized science communication

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Abstract

Amid the politicization of science and the globalization of technological applications, does the national-origin label of artificial intelligence authors affect their perceived credibility? Drawing on the tension between artificial intelligence as an apolitical referee (machine heuristic) and artificial intelligence as a geopolitical actor like humans (social identity theory and computers-are-social-actors paradigm), two online experiments were conducted in China to examine the role of author type (human, artificial intelligence, and human–artificial intelligence hybrid) and national-origin labels in scientific content with varying degrees of politicization. In a highly politicized context, domestic sources were preferred across all author types, with nationalism amplifying this preference. The effect of artificial intelligence's national-origin label was significant but weaker than that for human authors. In low-politicized contexts, the national-origin label no longer significantly affected artificial intelligence credibility, while foreign humans were perceived as more credible. These findings highlight the intersecting dynamics of scientific politicization and the public politicized understanding of artificial intelligence technology.

Keywords

artificial intelligence, nationalism, perceived credibility, politicization of science, authorship, machine heuristic, national-origin label effect

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I. Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) has rapidly evolved from a mere computational tool into a primary agent of science communication. From synthesizing climate reports to summarizing medical breakthroughs, AI-generated content (AIGC) is becoming ubiquitous in the public information landscape (Galaz et al., 2023; Henestrosa et al., 2023). As AI begins to speak science, audiences are faced with a novel challenge: evaluating the credibility of non-human agents. Existing research has largely focused on the technological attributes of AIGC, such as its anthropomorphism or transparency (Henestrosa et al., 2023; Jia et al., 2024; Waddell, 2018). However, these studies often operate under a tacit assumption that AI functions as a neutral, globalized, and apolitical entity. This assumption is increasingly at odds with the reality of how science is consumed in a polarized world.

Public understanding of science rarely occurs in a vacuum; it is deeply embedded in political contexts (Druckman, 2017). The politicization of science indicates that scientific issues, ranging from climate change to public health, are no longer debated solely on evidence but are embedded in ideological identities (Philipp-Muller et al., 2022). Against this backdrop, audiences will also evaluate science information based on political affiliations. This politicized public understanding of science has contributed to serious societal divisions on issues such as COVID-19 origins and climate change (Barceló et al., 2022; Jia and Luo, 2023). Under these conditions, audiences behave as cognitive misers, relying on heuristic cues, such as the source's identity, rather than on cognitive effort to judge credibility. While we know human experts are judged by their political or national-origin labels, a critical question arises: does this political heuristic apply to AI authors?

Ontologically, AI systems consist of computational algorithms and, as such, do not possess geographic boundaries or a "passport." Therefore, this study does not aim to explore the literal national or civic attributes of AI; rather, it focuses on the influence of AI's socially attributed national-origin cue. When AI is released to the public as a product of a particular company, audiences may infer overlapping signals from the developer company's country of origin, such as its governance infrastructure, regulatory environment, and geopolitical position. The underlying psychological mechanism is the Computers Are Social Actors (CASA) paradigm, where humans often ascribe social characteristics to computers (Reeves and Nass, 1996). In the current era of technonationalism (Kohno, 1995), AI is increasingly viewed not merely as a universal tool but as symbolically associated with national technological capacity, institutional arrangements, and geopolitical interests, similar to human agents. The global race for sovereign AI, exemplified by the rivalry between US-based models (e.g. ChatGPT, Gemini) and distinct counterparts in China (e.g. DeepSeek), South Korea (e.g. HyperCLOVA), or France (e.g. Mistral), has fused technological advancement with geopolitical identity (FDI Intelligence, 2025). Against this background, AI may be perceived as anchored in the national context, even though such anchoring remains socially interpreted rather than ontologically inherent. However, it remains unclear whether this national-origin cue attached to AI permeates the domain of scientific communication.

Theoretically, the role of AI's national-origin cues lies in two competing cognitive pathways: an unbiased, positive machine heuristic (Sundar, 2008) and a biased, geopolitical social heuristic based on the CASA paradigm. Specifically, we ask: against the backdrop of increasingly transnational dissemination of scientific findings, does the effect of an AI author's national-origin cue exist across different levels of politicized scientific content? Does a hostile national-origin label damage AI credibility even when the science content is relatively neutral?

As a result, two online experiments were conducted in China to test the effect of AI's national-origin label and examine its boundary conditions: politicization of the scientific information and individual differences, such as nationalism and scientific literacy. By having AI compete for the

identities of a geopolitical actor and a neutral vessel, this study contributes new insights to the public understanding of science, revealing how geopolitical friction shapes the reception of emerging technologies.

2. Literature review

AI authorship and machine heuristics in science communication

Authorship cues significantly shape credibility judgments (Sundar, 2008), yet empirical evidence on the credibility of AI versus human authors remains inconclusive, particularly in scientific communication. Some studies report that AI bylines reduce perceived credibility in scientific news, due to a lack of anthropomorphism and human nuance (Jia et al., 2024; Waddell, 2018). In contrast, other research suggests that AI is as credible as, or even more credible than, a human author when generating scientific messages, especially when addressing controversial scientific topics such as autonomous driving (Henestrosa et al., 2023), climate change, nuclear energy, and COVID-19 (Moon and Kahlor, 2025).

One possible reason for these inconsistent findings is that much existing literature treats AI as a decontextualized, general tool and ignores the politicized nature of scientific issues. Sundar's (2008) Modality-Agency-Interactivity-Navigability (MAIN) model offers a theoretical lens to reconcile these contradictions through the concept of "machine heuristic." It argues that individuals tend to ascribe machine-like qualities to technological agents (Cao et al., 2024), and such perceptions will be activated when individuals encounter AI rather than human authors (Lee, 2024).

Based on this perspective, scholars have further distinguished between negative and positive machine heuristics (Wang and Huang, 2024). The negative machine heuristic posits that machines lack some necessary capabilities, such as empathy and lived experience, so they struggle to grasp the implied meaning, leading to decreased trust and even algorithm aversion in science scenarios (Cao et al., 2024; Wang and Huang, 2024). Conversely, AI authors may also activate a positive machine heuristic, especially in politicized science contexts, with audiences believing that machines are neutral and free from political biases, which are important dimensions through which audiences assess credibility (Lee, 2024; Sundar, 2008). While human experts are suspected of motivated reasoning or partisan bias, AI authors, perceived as distinct from human ingroup/outgroup dynamics, may function as objective arbiters, thereby mitigating the hostile media effect and enhancing credibility (Chung et al., 2024; Moon and Kahlor, 2025). Thus, we propose that AI's credibility may depend on whether the audience needs human judgment or machine neutrality and put forward the following H1:

Hypothesis 1 (H1): Compared to human authors, AI authors will be perceived as (a) more credible in highly politicized scientific messages and (b) less credible in low politicized scientific messages.

National cues of human and AI authors: Social identity theory and CASA

Credibility is not solely determined by empirical evidence but is deeply shaped by the source's societal identity (Moon and Kahlor, 2025). Under these conditions, audiences behave as cognitive misers, evaluating scientific truth-claims based on cues such as race, ethnicity, or nationality (Wellman, 2024). This tendency is rooted in social identity theory, which posits that individuals derive self-esteem from their group memberships, thereby favoring authors that share their social identity while derogating out-group members (Tajfel and Turner, 2004). Hence, in politicized

information, a robust preference for domestic human authors over foreign ones is widely observed (Bryanov et al., 2023; Min and Luqiu, 2021).

Crucially, this effect of national-origin labels is not limited to human interactions but extends to technological artifacts. Social identity theory helps explain the national-origin label effect that is prevalent across different origin types, while the CASA paradigm can explain why this effect may also extend to AI authors. The CASA paradigm suggests that individuals unconsciously apply social heuristics to machines (Reeves and Nass, 1996), attributing human-like qualities to machines and treating AI like a human being (Cao et al., 2024). If machines function as social actors, they can also be explained by social identity theory and inevitably be socially categorized into national groups. Thus, the geopolitical identity of an AI is a salient heuristic cue, subjecting foreign AI to similarly negative evaluations as foreign humans (Chen et al., 2025; Eyssel and Kuchenbrandt, 2012). It gets further support by the recent Media-Are-Social-Actors (MASA) paradigm, which extends CASA to broader media technologies. It argues that different social cues presented by media can be interpreted as socially constructed heuristic signals that evoke diverse, deeply ingrained in-group/out-group responses (Lombard and Xu, 2021). In this paradigm, the media's social identity serves as a key signal that can be easily perceived (Lombard and Xu, 2021: 35).

AI author: An apolitical referee or geopolitical actor

This dynamic exposes a theoretical tension in AI-generated politicized scientific content, driven by two distinct paths of heuristic information processing. On the one hand, the machine heuristic derived from the MAIN model suggests that audiences may perceive AI as possessing machine-like qualities, such as objectivity, neutrality, and freedom from human political motivations (Chen et al., 2025; Chung et al., 2024). From this perspective, AI may function as an apolitical referee when its perceived neutrality and objectivity enhance credibility judgments in controversial scientific debates. On the other hand, the CASA and MASA paradigms help to extend social identity theory from human society to AI. They suggest that audiences may also deploy social heuristics toward AI, assigning it to national in-groups or out-groups and evaluating it through geopolitical identity cues (Cao et al., 2024; Lombard and Xu, 2021). From this perspective, foreign AI may be distrusted because audiences interpret its national-origin label as a cue to broader geopolitical associations.

This study, therefore, explores whether the audience resolves this tension by viewing AI as an apolitical referee, a geopolitical actor, or both (Lee, 2024). Specifically, we anticipate a main effect where domestic sources are favored over foreign ones across all author types. However, the foreign disadvantages may be mitigated in AI authorship due to positive machine heuristics, a buffer that foreign human authors lack. In other words, AI's national-origin label may activate social identity-based distrust, but its perceived machine objectivity may simultaneously mitigate that distrust.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Domestic authors will be perceived as more credible than foreign authors in scientific messages.

Hypothesis 3 (H3): There will be an interaction effect between author type and author's national-origin label, as the negative effect of the foreign label will be weaker for AI authors than for human authors.

Human–AI hybrid authorship and their national origins

Although the human–AI hybrid has been widely used in newsrooms (Wölker and Powell, 2021) and has been considered a future trend (Graefe, 2016), its effect has not been fully explored. The

credibility of hybrid authorship is theoretically important not only because it is common, but also because it reveals how audiences hierarchically assign epistemic agency when human and machine cues conflict. Some preliminary evidence suggests that people generally perceive co-authorship as a human-led process, in which humans bear primary responsibility, and AI acts as an assistant (Graefe, 2016). This assumption is also consistent with recent research that AI is a co-author within a human-in-the-loop framework under human oversight (Chen et al., 2026) and that they tend to value human control in hybrid authorship because it preserves accountability (Haupt et al., 2025). Notably, although some studies distinguished different collaboration patterns between humans and AI (Jia et al., 2024), these are beyond our research scope. We preliminarily expect the human author to serve as the primary credibility anchor when a message is described as written by a human author using an AI system.

Furthermore, the credibility of the co-authorship is under debate. It may not be different from that of a single human or machine author (Tandoc et al., 2020; Wölker and Powell, 2021), but some opposing evidence also exists. For example, one experimental study found that a human–AI hybrid has lower credibility than single human or AI authors in some conditions (Chen et al., 2025), while Waddell (2019) found a credibility improvement in human–AI hybrid authorship.

Finally, the credibility evaluation becomes more intricate when the human author's nationality and the AI system's national-origin label diverge (e.g. a domestic scientist using a foreign AI model). In such inconsistent hybrid dyads, a critical methodological question arises: which identity serves as the primary anchor for credibility? Drawing on the hierarchy of agency in human-machine collaboration, audiences typically perceive the human as the primary gatekeeper (Graefe, 2016) and the AI as a subservient pilot (Jia et al., 2024). Accordingly, in this study, the national-origin label of a hybrid author is operationally defined by the human operator. For example, the hybrid of a Chinese person using a US-based model (e.g. ChatGPT) is categorized as a Chinese author, albeit one utilizing foreign infrastructure. We term this specific configuration a cross-national hybrid, distinct from a same-country hybrid where both human and AI share the same national origins.

How do the inconsistent nationalities affect credibility? Marketing literature on consumer ethnocentrism suggests that purchasing or using foreign products can be perceived as unpatriotic or a violation of group norms (Kim, 2018; Spielmann and Minton, 2020). It implies that the potential effect of foreign AI might still exist even if it is used by domestic people. Conversely, for a foreign expert, using a domestic AI might act as a buffer, increasing their credibility by signaling an effort to use unbiased local tools (Chen et al., 2025; Kreps et al., 2022). Given the lack of direct evidence, we propose:

Research Question 1 (RQ1): How will the credibility of human–AI hybrid authors be perceived compared to that of single human or AI authors in scientific messages?

Research Question 2 (RQ2): How does the national-origin label of same-country or cross-national human–AI hybrid authors influence perceived credibility in scientific messages?

The moderating role of nationalism

A critical mechanism is nationalism that may shape how audiences navigate the tension between the unbiased, positive machine heuristic and biased nationality categorization. It was defined as a sense of national superiority and uncritical support for one's own group, often coupled with the derogation of out-groups (Blank and Schmidt, 2003). A substantial body of literature suggests nationalism as a powerful cognitive filter that may moderate how individuals process cross-national sources in politically charged issues (Jia and Luo, 2023; Spielmann and Minton, 2020). From a

social identity perspective, a high level of nationalism magnifies defensive processing, causing audiences to perceive foreign influence as a significant psychological and geopolitical threat (Spielmann and Minton, 2020) and actively devalue or dismiss information originating from foreign or rival nations.

This moderating effect is particularly significant in science domains. When scientific issues intersect with national interests, nationalism fuels motivated reasoning, overriding objective scientific consensus and driving a strong bias toward homegrown scientific solutions or narratives (Bogado, 2024; Jia and Luo, 2023; Liu and Zhang, 2025). Based on this mechanism, we expect nationalism to significantly condition the domestic favoritism toward authorship. However, it remains an open question whether this moderating effect applies equally to human, AI, or human–AI hybrid authors, especially given that AI is perceived as highly neutral. Therefore, we propose:

Hypothesis 4 (H4): Nationalism will moderate the effect of the author’s national-origin label on perceived credibility.

Research Question 3 (RQ3): Will there be a three-way interaction effect among author type, author’s national-origin label, and participants’ level of nationalism?

Different contexts in the politicization of science

The impact of author type and national-origin label cannot be understood in isolation from the topic’s context. The politicization of science refers to the process by which scientific issues become entangled with political ideologies and identity struggles (Druckman, 2017). When a scientific topic is highly politicized (e.g. climate change or COVID-19 origin), it ceases to be a matter of objective evidence and becomes a marker of group loyalty. In such contexts, audiences engage in motivated reasoning, filtering information to protect their worldview (Moon and Kahlor, 2025). As we pointed out above, AI authors may evoke positive (e.g. objectivity and unbiasedness) or negative (e.g. poor comprehension) dimensions of machine heuristics in different politicized contexts, thus triggering different main effects of author type. Furthermore, national-origin cues may also show a stronger local bias in highly politicized scientific messages, while being more moderate in less politicized scientific messages. Therefore, the following research question is proposed.

Research Question 4 (RQ4): Will the roles of author type, national-origin labels, and their interactions differ between highly politicized and low-politicized scientific messages?

If the “nationalistic lens” fades in importance under low-political conditions, what individual differences step in to shape credibility? One promising explanation lies in scientific literacy. It may affect how people understand AI authors and respond to scientific information through three different mechanisms.

First, individuals with lower scientific literacy rely more on heuristics, whereas those with higher literacy adopt more critical and analytical thinking (Jia and Luo, 2023; Li et al., 2026). From this perspective, scientific literacy may lead to less reliance on social heuristics (AI as a geopolitical actor) and machine heuristics (AI as an apolitical referee), weakening the role of the author type and national-origin label. Second, scientific literacy may also amplify rather than diminish the effect of the national-origin label. For example, Drummond and Fischhoff (2017) found that scientific literacy will intensify political polarization because these people are better able to selectively interpret evidence and defend their existing worldviews. Their higher cognitive ability facilitates motivated reasoning rather than eliminating it (Tappin et al., 2021). Some researchers have even

directly criticized scientific literacy as an ineffective intervention for science communication (Philipp-Muller et al., 2022). Finally, scientific literacy may also support trust in AI, rather than distrust, by helping audiences understand its usefulness for processing, summarizing, or explaining scientific information (Schiavo et al., 2024). Such trust is based on perceived technical utility and broader trust in science (Schäfer et al., 2024). Therefore, while remaining aware of its risks (Li et al., 2026), scientifically literate audiences may perceive AI as more credible in some contexts. Consequently, we ask:

Research Question 5 (RQ5): Will the audience's scientific literacy moderate the effects of author type on perceived credibility?

Research Question 6 (RQ6): Will the audience's scientific literacy moderate the interaction effects between author type and author's national-origin label on perceived credibility?

Taken together, this study organizes these theoretical perspectives into a layered framework. The core issue is the national-origin cues of AI authors in scientific information, with two competing explanations. The machine heuristic highlights AI's perceived objectivity and views it as an apolitical referee. But social identity theory explains political source bias, and CASA/MASA explains why such social cues may extend from human authors to AI systems. Surrounding the two theoretical derivations of AI's national-origin label, some textual context and individual differences are taken into account. The level of politicization in scientific information functions as the contextual condition that may activate or weaken national cues. And nationalism and scientific literacy are treated as individual-level moderators.

To address the research hypotheses and questions in this framework, we conducted two experiments. Experiment 1 examines the effects of author type and national-origin label in a highly politicized context. Experiment 2 replicates and extends the design in a low-politicized context to explore boundary conditions and also examines RQ5–6.

3. Experiment 1: Highly politicized scientific information

Method

Design. Given the significant impact of Sino-American competition and conflict on science, technology, and current global affairs (Chen et al., 2025; FDI Intelligence, 2025), the Chinese public provides a suitable sample for examining variations in credibility from different authors in a highly politicized scientific message. Approved by the internal review board of Shanghai Jiao Tong University (no. H20240469I), an online experiment was conducted in China in March 2024, with a 4 (author type: sole human vs sole AI vs cross-national human–AI hybrid vs same-country human–AI hybrid) $\times$ 2 (author's national-origin label: domestic vs foreign) between-subjects factorial design.

Sample and manipulation check. An a priori power analysis was conducted using G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2009). Based on a meta-analysis indicating a medium effect size ($d=0.32$) for AI credibility in socio-political news (Wang and Huang, 2024), a minimum sample size of 309 was required to achieve a statistical power of 80% at a significance level of 0.05.

An initial pool of 903 university students from eastern China was recruited. To ensure data quality, participants who could not correctly identify their assigned author source from eight options were considered to fail the manipulation check and thereby excluded. This data cleaning process yielded a final valid sample of 472 university students, with each receiving 2 CNY (1 USD $\approx$ 7

CNY). The retained sample included 289 males (61.2%) and 183 females (38.8%), with an average age of 22.48 years ($SD=4.82$) and a majority holding a bachelor's degree (62.7%). A randomization check using chi-square tests and one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) confirmed no significant differences in demographics across the eight experimental conditions, ensuring successful randomization.

Stimuli and procedure. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the eight experimental conditions. Aside from the manipulation of author information, all textual content remained identical. To simulate a highly politicized scientific context, we fabricated a 480-word news article titled "Human Genome Association Study." The article framed genetic research through a geopolitical lens, discussing how human genetic data, while useful for disease research, could be exploited by US political institutions for targeted bioweapons or espionage. This narrative strategy ensured the topic was perceived as a matter of national security and international competition, rather than neutral scientific dissemination.

The story was assigned different author information across the eight groups. The Chinese and American human authors were named *Chenhan Xu* and *Cameron Blake*, respectively, both relatively neutral names to avoid gender bias. The machine authors were *Zhiwen 4.0*, AI from China (*Zhiwen* means wisdom in Chinese), and *ThoughtFlow 4.0*, AI from the United States. These two AI names were also fictitious. Finally, participants in the hybrid-author group saw that the author was *Chenhan* or *Cameron*, using either *Zhiwen* or *ThoughtFlow 4.0*. After exposure to the stimuli, participants were required to finish the following questionnaire, thanked, and told that the experimental story was fictitious. The full experimental stimuli and questionnaires are provided in the Supplemental Material.

Measures. *Perceived credibility* means the author offers reasonable grounds for being believed (Meyer, 1988). It was assessed using seven 7-point *Likert*-type items ranging from 1 (*completely disagree*) to 7 (*completely agree*) from Meyer (1988). Items include "this author was 'fair and objective,' 'unbiased/neutral,' 'complete,' 'trustworthy,' 'professional,' 'accurate,' and 'generally credible'" ($M=4.82$, $SD=1.29$, Cronbach's $\alpha=.96$).

Nationalism to capture nationalistic leaning, participants were asked to report their degree of agreement with the given statements on the same *Likert*-type scale, with the five adopted items (Hyun and Kim, 2015), such as "Chinese culture/traditional value is superior to other cultures/civilizations in the world," and "When China has a serious conflict of interest with other nations, we can use any means to defend our own interests" ($M=5.30$, $SD=1.22$, Cronbach's $\alpha=.90$).

Results

An analysis of covariance (ANCOVA) was conducted with perceived credibility as the dependent variable, author type and national-origin label as fixed factors, and nationalism as a covariate.

The main effects of different author types and nationalities. Regarding H1, H2, and RQ1, there was a significant main effect of author type ($F(3,456)=3.48$, $\eta^2=.02$, $p=.016$) and author's national-origin label ($F(1,456)=49.69$, $\eta^2=.09$, $p<.001$). Pairwise comparisons with Tukey adjustment indicated that sole human authors ($M=4.57$, $SE=0.11$) had significantly lower credibility than same-country hybrid authors ($M=4.98$, $SE=0.11$, $t(456)=-2.71$, $p=.036$) or single AI authors ($M=4.96$, $SE=0.11$, $t(456)=-2.58$, $p=.050$). No significant difference was observed between AI and same-country hybrid authors, nor between sole human and cross-national hybrid authors. In

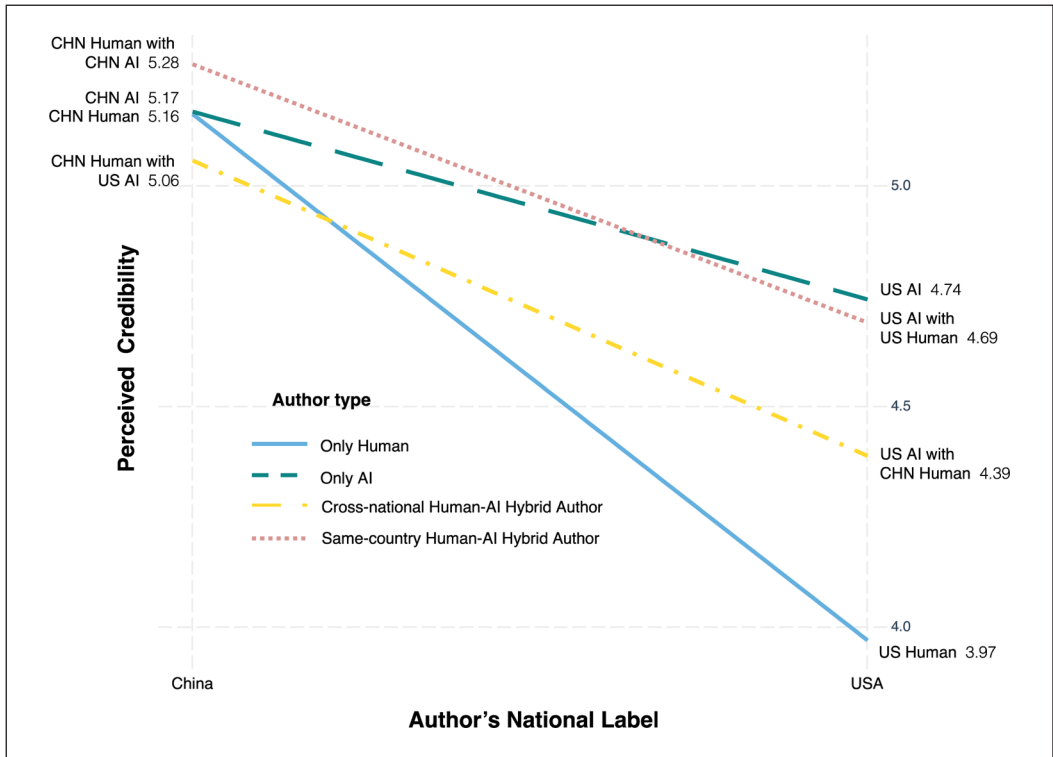


Figure 1. Interaction effects of author type and author's national-origin label on perceived credibility in a highly politicized scientific message (Experiment 1).

Note. Means were adjusted for the group differences on the covariate (nationalism) and reported in the figure.

addition, Chinese authors ($M=5.17$, $SE=0.08$) were significantly more credible than American authors ($M=4.45$, $SE=0.08$, $t(456)=6.60$, $p<.001$). Hence, H1(a) and H2 were supported, and RQ1 was answered.

The interaction effect of author type and national-origin label. In terms of H3 and RQ2, there was a significant interaction effect between author type and author's national-origin label ($F(3,456)=2.74$, $\eta^2=.01$, $p=.043$). Post hoc Tukey tests indicated that the author's foreign cues played a significantly negative role for single human authors ($M_{China}=5.16$, $SE=0.15$; $M_{USA}=3.97$, $SE=0.15$, $t(456)=5.64$, $p<.001$) and cross-national hybrid authors ($M_{China}=5.06$, $SE=0.17$; $M_{USA}=4.39$, $SE=0.15$, $t(456)=3.02$, $p=.003$). However, this decreasing trend became more gradual for single AI authors ($M_{China}=5.17$, $SE=0.16$; $M_{USA}=4.74$, $SE=0.15$, $t(456)=1.99$, $p=.047$) and same-country hybrid authors ($M_{China}=5.28$, $SE=0.16$; $M_{USA}=4.69$, $SE=0.16$, $t(456)=2.62$, $p=.009$). In other words, when sole humans and cross-national human-AI hybrid authors were involved, the effect of national-origin label on perceived credibility was more drastic (as shown in Figure 1).

Nationalism as a moderator. Regarding H4, nationalism significantly moderated the effect of author's national-origin label on perceived credibility ($F(1,456)=8.53$, $\eta^2=.01$, $p=.004$). As shown in Figure 2, the effect of the author's national-origin label would be amplified for

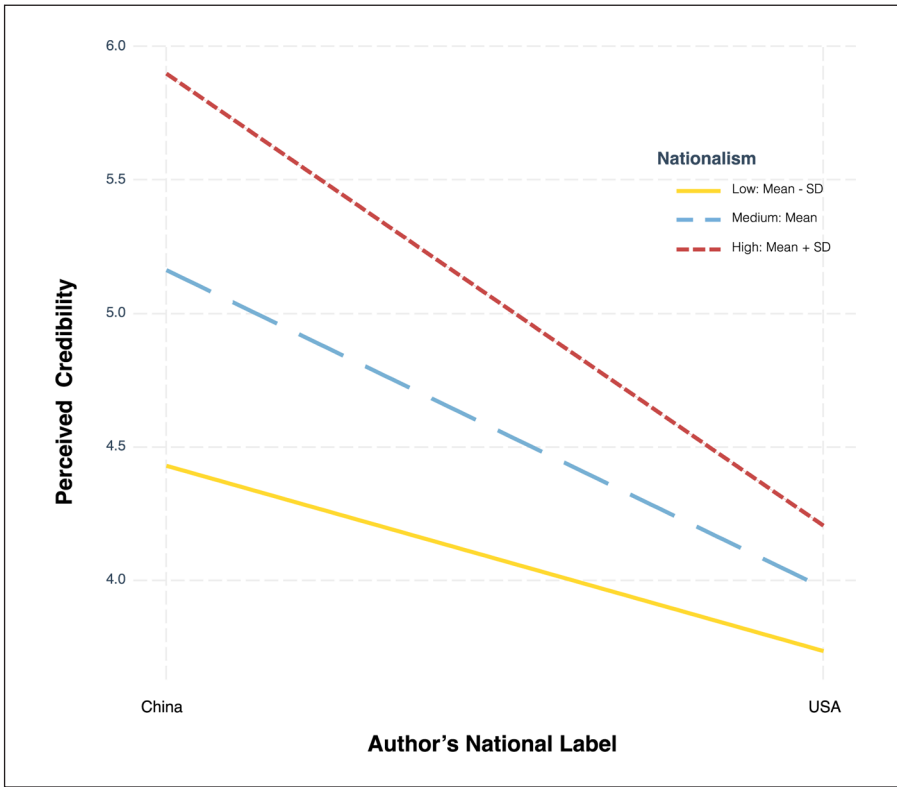


Figure 2. The moderating effect of nationalism on the relationship between author's national-origin label and perceived credibility in a highly politicized scientific message (Experiment 1).

participants with high nationalism. In contrast, less nationalistic individuals showed a moderate change caused by national cues, supporting H4.

Concerning RQ3, a non-significant three-way interaction was found among author type, national-origin label, and individual nationalism, suggesting that the moderating effect of nationalism on the national bias did not vary significantly across human, AI, or hybrid authors.

Discussion

Using a message stimulus intersecting science and politics, Experiment 1 found a preference toward the domestic authors, which was amplified by nationalism and was significantly observed across all author types. The interaction effect further implied that foreign AI or foreign same-country hybrid authors were treated with a slight decrease in credibility. These findings align with the political spillover effect (Engelhardt and Utych, 2020), where political cues in ostensibly apolitical domains (like science) trigger defensive processing. Participants were prompted to evaluate credibility based on their political endorsement heuristic thinking rather than scientific merit (Chen et al., 2025; Philipp-Muller et al., 2022).

However, valid questions remain regarding the generalizability of these findings. If the context is depoliticized, political identity defenses may remain dormant (Engelhardt and Utych, 2020). In such a low-politicized context, we argue that the primary heuristic may shift. Without the urgent

need for a neutral AI or a domestic author, which was favored in Experiment 1, the public may revert to the negative machine heuristic that AI lacks human-like qualities such as anthropomorphism and comprehension, and the role of national-origin label and nationalism may be weakened in an apolitical scientific context.

4. Experiment 2: Low-politicized scientific information

Method

Design, procedure, and stimuli. Experiment 2 replicated the same between-subjects design and procedure used in Experiment 1. The stimulus article, titled “Human Genome Association Study,” was identical in the scientific message to Experiment 1 to ensure comparability. However, to create a low-politicized context, the narrative focused exclusively on the medical benefits of genetic research for human well-being, removing all references to geopolitical rivalry, espionage, or political interests. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the eight author conditions. They then completed the reading, passed the manipulation check, and finished the survey.

Sample. We recruited participants via the *WenJuanXing* (www.wjx.cn) in September 2025, China’s largest online survey platform. *WenJuanXing* automatically removed 120 participants because they failed to recall the author. The final valid sample size was 414, including 243 (58.7%) women and 171 (41.3%) men with an average age of 32.77 years ($SD=7.92$), most of whom (79.7%) had a bachelor’s degree. The median monthly household income ranged from 10,001 to 15,000 CNY. Randomization checks confirmed no significant demographic differences across the eight conditions.

Measures. With the same measurement as in Experiment 1, *perceived credibility* ($M=5.19$, $SD=0.89$, Cronbach’s $\alpha=.87$) and *nationalism* ($M=5.59$, $SD=0.85$, Cronbach’s $\alpha=.72$) were gauged.

Scientific literacy was assessed using four validated items from the National Science Board (2020), following recommendations (Mede et al., 2026). The total number of correct answers, ranging from zero to four, was summed to form an index of scientific literacy ($M=2.97$, $SD=0.91$).

Results

An ANCOVA with nationalism and scientific literacy as moderating covariates was conducted.

The main effect of different author types and nationalities. Regarding RQ1 and H1(b), no significant difference was found among different author types ($F(3,390)=0.76$, $\eta^2<.001$, $p=.518$). Thus, H1(b) was not supported.

In terms of H2, which predicted a preference for domestic authors, a main effect of authors’ national-origin label was supported ($F(1,390)=3.92$, $\eta^2=.01$, $p=.048$). However, the direction was opposite to the hypothesis and Experiment 1. Chinese authors ($M=5.09$, $SE=0.06$) were significantly less credible than American ($M=5.28$, $SE=0.06$, $t(390)=-2.32$, $p=.021$). Thus, H2 was reversed and rejected in the low-politicized context.

The interaction effect of author type and national-origin label. For H3 and RQ2, as shown in Figure 3, the significant two-way interaction effect between author type and author’s national-origin label was observed ($F(3,390)=3.08$, $\eta^2=.02$, $p=.027$). Tukey’s post hoc test was conducted, indicating that an

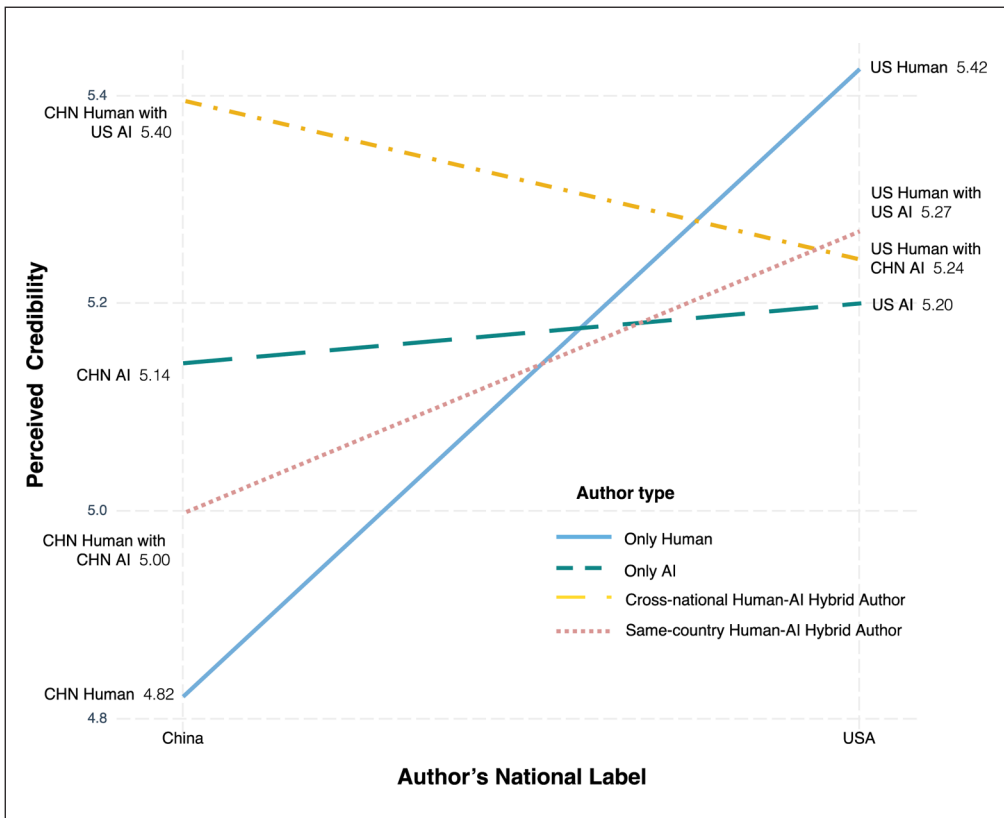


Figure 3. Interaction effects of author type and author's national-origin label on perceived credibility in a low-politicized scientific message (Experiment 2).

Note. Means were adjusted for the group differences on the covariate (nationalism and scientific literacy) and reported in the figure.

American human ($M=5.42$, $SE=.12$) was significantly more credible than Chinese human authors ($M=4.82$, $SE=0.12$, $t(390)=-3.57$, $p<.001$). But the national cues did not influence perceived credibility for AI, same-country human-AI hybrid authors, or cross-national hybrid authors.

Individual differences: The moderation of nationalism and scientific literacy. Concerning RQ3 and H4, the interaction term between author's national-origin label and nationalism did not reach significance ($F(1,390)=0.01$, $\eta^2=.00$, $p=.936$), suggesting the general moderating effect of nationalism found in Experiment 1 did not replicate here.

But the three-way interaction among author type, author's national-origin label, and nationalism was significant ($F(3,390)=4.37$, $\eta^2=.03$, $p=.005$). PROCESS macro Model 3 was utilized for further analysis (see Figure 4). It showed that for individuals with a low level of nationalism, a foreign cue was positive to perceived credibility for same-country hybrid authors ($B=0.74$, $SE=0.24$, $p=.002$), while it also negatively impacted credibility for cross-national hybrid authors ($B=-0.50$, $SE=0.25$, $p=.047$). However, the effect of the national-origin label in both types of hybrid authors became non-significant for participants with high nationalism. For sole human authors, American authors were consistently more credible than Chinese authors across different levels of nationalism.

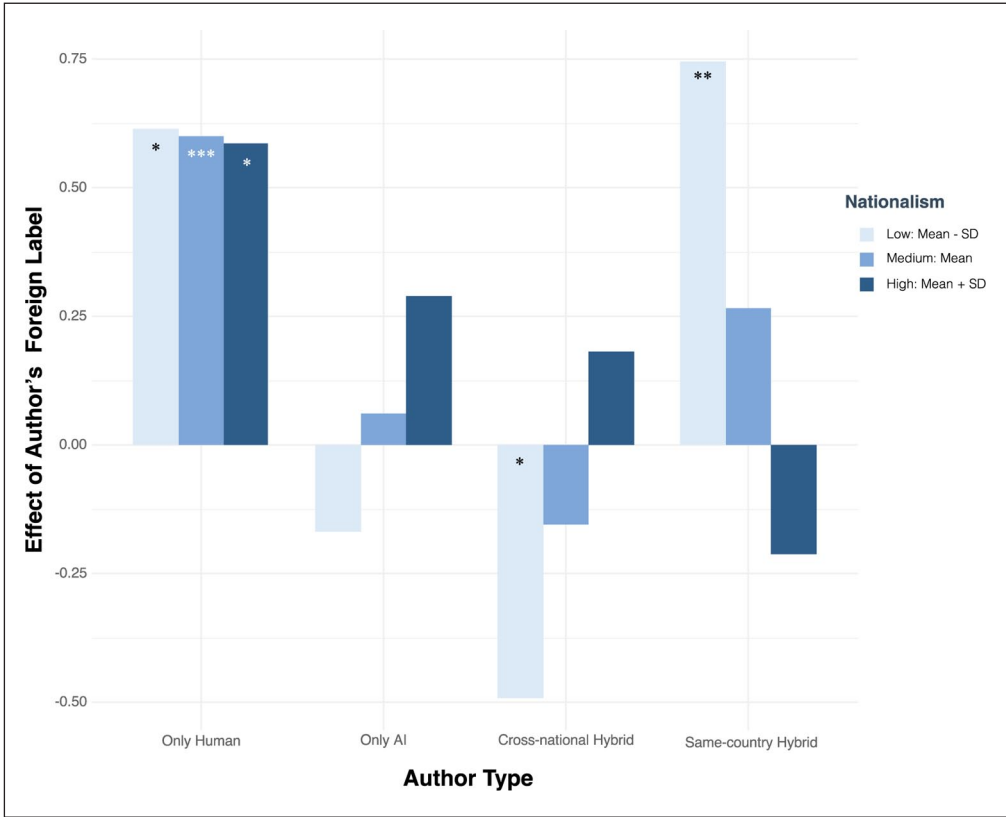


Figure 4. Three-way interaction among author type, author's national-origin label and nationalism in a low-politicized scientific message (Experiment 2).

Note. The results were based on PROCESS Model 3.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Concerning RQ5 and RQ6, scientific literacy did not significantly moderate the impact of author type ($F(3,390)=1.25$, $\eta^2=.01$, $p=.291$). But a significant three-way interaction term (see Figure 5) was found among scientific literacy, author type and national-origin label ($F(3,390)=2.83$, $\eta^2=.02$, $p=.038$). According to the PROCESS Model 3, as scientific literacy improved, the credibility growth caused by a foreign label further increased for human authors and same-country hybrid authors. This suggested that individuals with high scientific literacy tended to favor foreign authors in the two categories above. Furthermore, among AI and cross-national hybrid authors, increased scientific literacy increased preference for authors from their own country, but it did not reach statistical significance.

5. General discussion

The central objective of this study was to investigate the effect of AI's national-origin label in science communication, specifically, whether foreign AI is evaluated as more credible due to the positive heuristic or less credible under the social identity theory. Two experiments in China suggest that, first, the politicized nature of scientific messages serves as a critical boundary condition, determining whether the national-origin cues of an AI author affect credibility judgments. Second, the effect of AI's

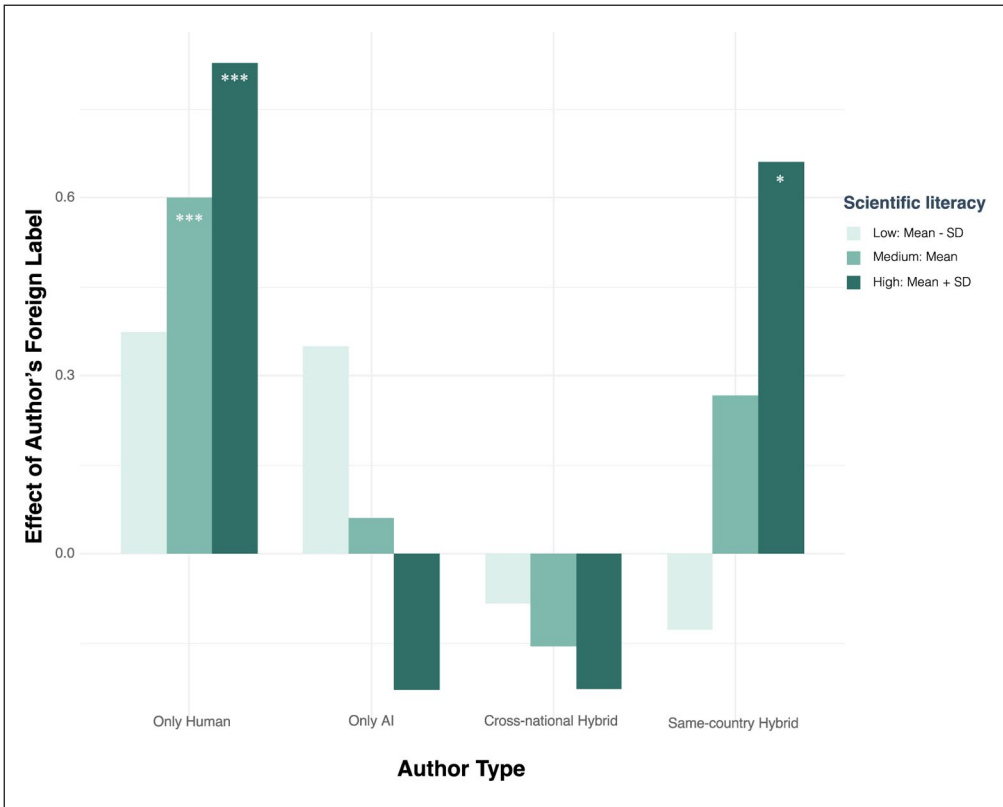


Figure 5. Three-way interaction among author type, author's national-origin label and scientific literacy in a low-politicized scientific message (Experiment 2).

Note. The results were based on PROCESS Model 3.

* $p < .05$. *** $p < .001$.

national-origin label is significant in highly politicized scientific information, but weaker than that of human authors. Third, individual differences, nationalism and scientific literacy also influence for whom these source identities matter most. These findings need further discussion.

Key findings

First, we find that AI's national-origin label effect differs based on the level of scientific politicization. In low-politicization contexts, national cues had limited influence on AI credibility judgments. Audiences exhibit a cosmopolitan openness to foreign human authors (Noy and O'Brien, 2019). It aligns with the sociology argument that attitudes toward science are essentially cultural tastes acquired through contact with Western cultural institutions (Noy and O'Brien, 2019). However, once scientific information is framed within a highly politicized context, national cues abruptly reverse direction. A robust domestic preference emerges across all authorship types. This contextual flip is consistent with social identity theory. It may be driven by the heightened geopolitical threat perception and negative emotional arousal inherent in our highly politicized stimuli. In such cases, participants appeared to privilege domestic authors, indicating that national-origin cues may outweigh the universalist ideal of science in credibility judgments.

Second, using human authorship as a comparative baseline, we observed that AI's national-origin label effect was buffered but still significant in politicized contexts. It challenges the assumption that machines are always treated as nationality-free and purely politically neutral (Chung et al., 2024; Hong et al., 2025). Our findings are consistent with the possibility that audiences used social heuristics toward technology and treated AI national-origin labels as in-group/out-group cues. Consequently, foreign AI suffers a significant credibility decline, indicating it may serve as a geopolitical actor under the CASA paradigm (Eyssel and Kuchenbrandt, 2012; Lombard and Xu, 2021).

However, the weaker disadvantage for foreign AI than for foreign human authors suggests that perceived machine neutrality may have weakened, rather than eliminated, negative reactions to foreign national-origin labels (Chen et al., 2025; Chung et al., 2024). It indicates that AI is evaluated by being shaped by both geopolitical source cues and assumptions of machine neutrality. Furthermore, in human–AI hybrid conditions, audiences appeared to rely on the human author as the primary identity anchor to process geopolitical cues, although this dynamic might fluctuate depending on the perceived degree of AI's agency in the task (Jia et al., 2024). This hybrid identity underpins both the CASA paradigm and the MAIN model.

Finally, the effect of the national-origin label is not uniform; it varies among different audiences. Our results show that nationalism amplifies the credibility advantage of domestic authors only in politicized contexts, while it hardly works in low-politicized settings. It is consistent with nationalism becoming especially relevant when scientific issues are framed as geopolitical threats. Under this interpretation, AI may shift from being evaluated as a scientific tool to being seen, in part, as a symbol of national identity and a potential target for in-group defense (Kohno, 1995).

Theoretical and practical implications

Theoretically, this study advances the literature on AI and science communication by unpacking the boundary conditions of the AI national-origin label effect, thereby addressing a critical theoretical tension between two contrasting heuristic pathways (Cao et al., 2024; Lee, 2024). On one hand, the positive machine heuristic posits that audiences rely on machine-like qualities, perceiving AI as objective and free from human bias. On the other hand, the CASA paradigm suggests that individuals unconsciously apply human-like qualities to machines. According to the recent MASA framework, an extension of CASA, social signals like national origins from media technologies can evoke social responses (Lombard and Xu, 2021), which compete with AI's perceived objectivity.

Second, the findings establish the boundary conditions of the machine heuristic, contributing to the AIGC studies. In low-politicized contexts, we found no significant difference in credibility between human and AI authors (the null finding for H1b). This suggests that the positive machine heuristic may offset the negative machine heuristic (the lack of human nuance and empathy; Waddell, 2018; Wang and Huang, 2024), as emotional resonance is less critical when transmitting depoliticized scientific facts. Conversely, for high-politicized scientific information, optimistic scholars have argued that the objectivity heuristic of AI could alleviate social polarization (Chung et al., 2024; Hong et al., 2025). Our Experiment 1 provides nuanced support for this perspective while this buffering effect is fragile. As evidenced by the hybrid authors, when a domestic human uses a foreign AI, the credibility shows a marked decrease. It further implies that the manifestation of machine heuristics is highly context-dependent and shaped by both the political environment and the user's geopolitical identity.

These findings also offer practical suggestions for science communicators navigating the AI era. First, practitioners can benefit from tailoring their sourcing strategies to the political sensitivity of

the topic. For politically contested issues (e.g. genetic security, climate change), emphasizing domestic human or AI authors may be necessary to maintain public trust. Conversely, for unpoliticized basic science (e.g. astronomy), highlighting a foreign author remains an effective credibility signal. Besides, the complexity of hybrid authorship demands careful disclosure. If scientific communicators wish to leverage AI's relatively neutral identity to deliver politicized scientific information, it would be better to maintain consistency in national cues. Finally, developers and platforms often present AI as a universal tool, yet audiences may inevitably focus on its socially attributed cues. This indicates that transparency regarding an AI's training data provenance and governance structure is important to maintain its ability to communicate scientific consensus.

Limitations and future research

The findings need to be carefully considered with some limitations. First, the highly politicized scientific message may introduce threat perception and negative emotional arousal, which may have mediating effects caused by politicized scientific information, requiring further investigation. In addition, an 18-month interval separated the two experiments, which may impact their comparison. Despite this, the internal validity of each experiment was stable. And the macro geopolitical environment (i.e. the technological U.S.-Sino rivalry) and the underlying theoretical mechanisms remained consistently salient throughout this period. Moreover, this study measured scientific literacy using four true-or-false questions, which may not fully capture its multiple dimensions. For example, science-related critical thinking and media use may also have an impact (Mede et al., 2026).

In addition, the findings on human–AI hybrid authorship should be interpreted within the specific authorship pattern. We exploratorily treated the human author as the primary national origin anchor, based on some preliminary evidence of a human–AI hybrid. However, perceived agency in human–AI collaboration might be context-dependent (Haupt et al., 2025; Jia et al., 2024). If AI is framed as a highly agentic collaborator, audiences may assign more responsibility and credibility weight to the AI than to the human operator. Future research should directly manipulate or measure perceived AI contribution to examine which element becomes a dominant credibility anchor.

Furthermore, it is important to acknowledge that foreign origin was operationalized exclusively as the United States for the Chinese participants. Given the current intense US–Sino rivalry, the decreased credibility of foreign authorship observed in highly politicized scenarios may represent an extreme manifestation of defensive techno-nationalism. But it remains an open empirical question for future research: whether these results would be generalizable to other national contexts, less politically polarized environments, or different bilateral relationships.

Finally, the experimental stimuli relied on a single issue of gene technology. Future research can extend the present design by incorporating a broader range of scientific topics, such as climate change or vaccination, to ensure that the effects of politicization are not restricted to a particular scientific domain.

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Supplemental material

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